

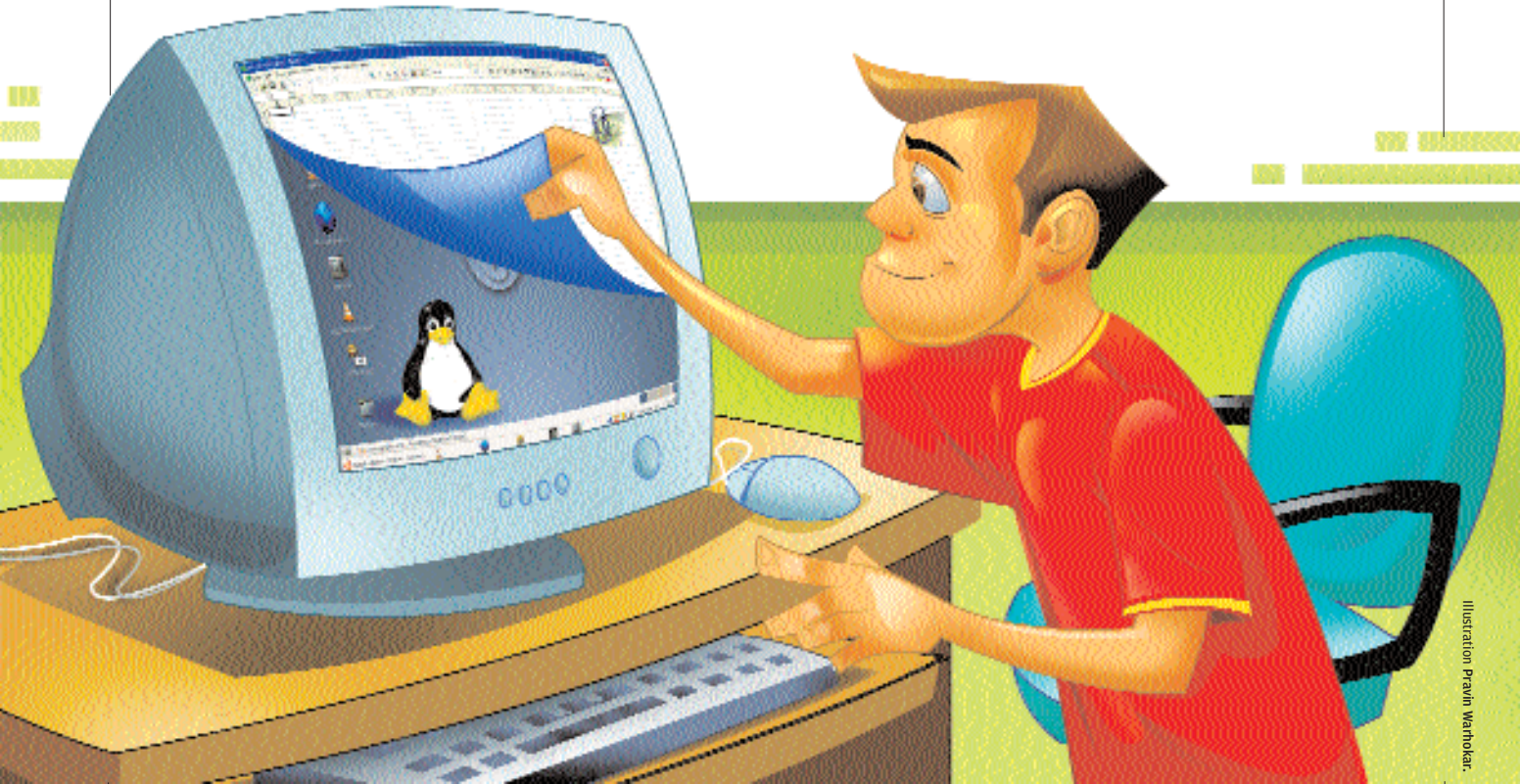


Illustration Pravin Warhakar.

What Lies Beneath

Been wondering if you should go the way of The Penguin, but don't want to part with your essential Windows programs? Here's how to get the best of both worlds

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There's been a lot of talk about Linux having "finally arrived" and "ready for your desktop" in these pages, and if you've read last month's *Fast Track to Open Source Software*, you'll notice that one of the longest lists of software is under the Office Tools category. For the SoHo owner, things couldn't have been better—Linux is free, there aren't any major security issues you need to worry about (the few viruses that do exist for Linux are hardly harmful), and the desktop environments—both GNOME and KDE—have reached levels of usability that are quite newcomer-friendly.

So why isn't everyone ditching Windows and opting for Linux? You obviously save financially, more so if you have multiple PCs, because multiple licenses of Windows XP can be quite an expense. The trouble lies with the applications: even today, few applications for Linux can match up to their Windows counterparts. OpenOffice.org Writer, for example, is a decent word processor, but the rest of the suite—Calc or Impress, for instance—hardly match up to Microsoft Excel or PowerPoint. And there's really no mail client that offers office users the kind of features that Outlook does. There are more such

examples, but you get the drift. So not only are you stuck shelling out for such essentials, you're stuck paying for Windows to run them!

There is a way you can save on your OS costs, though. You could still switch to Linux, and thanks to software like CrossOver (www.codeweavers.com) and Wine (www.winehq.com), you can run your Windows applications within Linux itself. These programs give Windows applications a "friendly environment" to run in, essentially fooling them into believing they're running inside the OS they're supposed to. CrossOver is actually a paid version of Wine, offering you a bunch of extra features and more user-friendliness.

How It Works

When an application wants to send information to the system's hardware—even something as simple as telling the graphics card to display its window on the screen—it has to do it through the OS, using a set of functions called APIs—Application Programming Interfaces. APIs eliminate the need for applications to know what hardware it's running on, which is why programs run the same way on any machine.

Windows applications thus use the Windows API—Microsoft releases it in the Windows SDK—to get things done; its demand isn't Windows per se, just as long as it's got an API to talk to. The